From: Edward Snook
To: Scanning; SBC Development Control
Subject: FW: Ref: S/RES/24/0947 - A3 - Parcels R6 & R7 South Marston
Date: 25 September 2024 10:57:00
Attachments: image009.png
image010.png
image011.png
image012.png
image001.png
image002.png

From: Peter Garitsis <PGaritsis@swindon.gov.uk>
Sent: 24 September 2024 12:59
To: Jonathan Chick <j.chick@nexusplanning.co.uk>
Cc: Edward Snook <ESnook@swindon.gov.uk>; Rob Stroud <Rob.Stroud@vistry.co.uk>; Chetan.Solanki@vistry.co.uk; Rachel Whiting <Rachel.Whiting@vistry.co.uk>; Daniel Sharp <d.sharp@nexusplanning.co.uk>; Tony Clements <t.clements@nexusplanning.co.uk>; Andrew.Cull@vistry.co.uk
Subject: RE: Ref: S/RES/24/0947 - A3 - Parcels R6 & R7 South Marston

Hi Jonathan,

Please find my comments below, apologies these are late we have been prioritising local plan evidence work over the past couple months.
I have had a look at the scheme in detail and last week with Ed Snook too and have made some comments below with regards to what the issues are in design terms, and importantly how they can be addressed moving forwards to achieve good design and placemaking out of this development.

Happy to discuss these in more detail at the workshop on Thursday.

Kind regards
Peter

S/RES/24/0947
RE: Reserved matters application (access, appearance, layout, scale and landscaping) for 137 dwellings and associated infrastructure - Reserved Matters from previous outline permission S/OUT/13/1555.
AT: Parcels R6 And R7 Land North Of A420 Swindon

- **Block Structure**: The block structure, particularly the large central block in parcel R7, appears to create a cramped environment for many of the plots with a streetscene dominated by car parking. The configuration of the block here is too large and in particular too deep to achieve a satisfactory traditional perimeter block. Instead half the block is compromised by frontages facing backs/sides and a large turning head is required to manoeuvre refuse vehicles and to achieve access to properties. This larger block compromises the scheme's wider legibility and character.
  Here are a few possible options/thoughts to consider (untested):
  - A series of smaller blocks are proposed to break up the central structure and connect to the other access roads and blocks;
  - A central space is located to bring a heart to the development, to add a placemaking element including trees and landscape to enhance the block and contribute to its identity. This would allow the rectilinear block (plots 53-61 and 34-42 to be established as a strong linear block, with a central green village space to the east of plots 34-42 with access etc.
  - Consider the wider block structure and create a high degree of legibility and connectivity across the parcel. This may mean altering a few block configurations to allow some rationalising of the central block. Consider how one moves around the housing parcel.
  - There are other possibilities – a great way to test this is through tissue studies of good precedent elsewhere. Where narrow blocks are proposed that cannot achieve standard plot depths (back to back) then a few bespoke house types could be included here to both maximise site value and enhance place value. See plot depths for example at Accordia (26m deep) with frontages both sides. Clever internal amenity designs without any negative outlook or privacy concerns. This requires a slightly different approach to standardised housing, but is not too far a stretch to be included here (in my view).
  - A number of the plots have unacceptably small gardens.
  - Connectivity: Provide additional pedestrian connection route near south-west corner of Plot R6.

- **Street scenes, urban/village character** – There is a lack of continuity of frontage and/or a lack of composition across streets. What we are looking for on this site are a series of characterful streets. This requires a lot more consideration of achieving a more continuous form of building line. Strong and consistent approach to boundary treatments throughout, and a more place-based approach to delivering a sense of character.
- At present the scheme's character is heavily influenced by the design of the public highway and car parking. This should be reversed to establish a landscape and urban design-led approach to place. Take the main routes and edges of the scheme and apply a place-based approach. This should be the starting point – move building types to suit the street type, use boundary treatments to suit the intended character and manoeuvre the design of the street including verges, trees and any other spaces to establish the 'vision' or 'identity' of the place.

- **Architecture and character** - the architecture of the dwellings should be enhanced from the currently proposed street scenes to be much more characterful.
  The current street scenes (example snippets below) are lacking in quality and character and with some revisions could be severely improved.

  Roof forms for instance could be more animated with a more playful response to the resulting 'place'.
  By this I refer to the inclusion of more gable-fronted properties/aspects, a mix of dormer windows, possibly bay windows, door and window surrounds, chimneys, front porches, recessed porches and brick detailing. Such are the details and forms of buildings within more rural settings/villages that when applied to a much more urban context, will be more characterful. This in turn adds to the feel and value of the environment and the quality of development, and contributes to its distinctive character. There are also examples where a more simple, stripped down version of typologies can work, but this needs to be matched with very careful detailing, materials and landscape architecture to suit this approach.

  The quality and character of streets is not limited to the architecture of the facades only and is also heavily dependent on the other elements that make place: landscape design, street trees, lighting columns, boundary treatments, choice of materials, setback of frontages, building lines, etc.

  Below (current streetscenes) Top streetscene lacks quality in its monotony and perhaps fails to bring the individual qualities / complexities naturally found within the surrounding character of South Marston. Without wanting to simply copy such places, there are ways in which a more evocative response can be established.
  The bottom streetscene is very different, but also aiming at a different style with hipped red roof forms are uncharacteristic features within the historic village.
  I would suggest a short precedent study is produced of the good aspects of architecture and places responsive to S. Marston, together with examples of schemes elsewhere that have produced a high quality environment.

  Materials: whilst the Character Area Design Code (CADC) provides options of 4 materials, in these parcels it is suggested that the range of materials used be reduced to a much more simplified palette. In particular, it would be more effective to apply the choice of materials to the proposal once the house types and street scenes are more developed. It could be that only one main material (say brick) is used with another contrasting material for accents such as surrounds etc.

Hope these comments are helpful, happy to discuss,

Kind regards

Peter Garitsis
Senior Urban Designer
PLACEmaking Team

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